

begins to show up in everyday life: phones remain unanswered to avoid bill collectors and a good night's sleep becomes a rarity as financial worries mount. You may become angry, irritable, or depressed, or feel defeated if you find yourself being managed by your money instead of the other way around. When your money has started to manage you, you give up your control. For example, you may believe in paying your bills on time, but if the due date has arrived and you don't have the money, you will be forced to pay your bills late or borrow money—situations that no one wants to encounter.

Getting control back is crucial to raising your self-esteem and making yourself the master of your own destiny. From very early on I was told that “Money doesn't buy happiness.” This is true, but happiness cannot be assured through poverty either. An amazing thing happened to me when I got myself out of debt for the first time in my life. Since I was no longer worried about how I was going to pay my bills, I became happier! The joy that came from knowing that I was not constrained by debt and that I had savings to tide me over in case of an unexpected life event (one that causes a major expense) proved liberating.

Before I learned how to manage my money, I was always panic stricken when an unexpected expense or event came up. Learning how to stay out of debt and maintain a savings cushion has solved that problem. Unexpected expenses and life events now become temporary inconveniences instead of crises. For example, if you lose your job when finances are troubled, most likely you will be forced to take the first job offered and won't have the luxury of waiting for a job that you really want. This is exactly the type of scenario you want to avoid. By providing a secure financial foundation for yourself, you ensure

